

P.V. Sindhu, *28*
Badminton ace

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

Holding Court

IN A COUNTRY THAT FOR LONG has had a dearth of sporting talent, few have made a mark like Pusarla Venkata Sindhu. The ace shuttler is insatiable, having already achieved two unprecedented feats for an Indian athlete—the first and only one to become a badminton world champion in 2019, and that too between winning medals (a silver and a bronze) at two consecutive Olympics. Now, preparing for Paris 2024, the 28-year-old is eyeing another Olympic medal, hopefully gold this time.

But the five-time World Championships medallist has struggled with injury since last August, even as she won gold at the 2022 Commonwealth Games in Birmingham. She hopes to change that soon. "In going for gold at the next Olympics, I have to give my best every day," she says. "For, it is a long journey even before getting to Paris. This drives me to work hard every day—to be physically and mentally stronger. It is going to be tough." Appreciating her determination and helping add a few tweaks to her game is the veteran Prakash Padukone, India's first All England champion.

Sindhu was 10 when she accompanied her father, P.V. Ramana, an Arjuna Award-winning volleyball player, to a game, but became more fascinated by what was happening on the badminton courts next door. With that began her love for the sport. Before dawn, every weekday, Ramana would give her a ride to the academy run by India's other All England champion and fellow Hyderabadi Pullela Gopichand. Later, the family even shifted near the academy to provide Sindhu enough time to train on her speed, strength and endurance. Predictably, under the tutelage of Gopichand, she played on the international circuit for the first time at 14, in 2009, and has since gone places to emerge as a formidable player and a champion.

An innate asset is her willingness to take suggestions from others—a rare quality among top sportspersons. This coupled with her aura as a lanky and aggressive player, who uses her height to reach all corners of the court, makes her rivals wary of her game. Currently ranked World No. 11—well below her career best of No. 2 back in 2017—Sindhu has set out clear goals for herself in 2024. The coming year may very well be a historic one for her, and for India. ■

-Amarnath K. Menon

STAYING GROUNDED

"Success is always the culmination of hard work...and never forget how you started off"

WHO INSPIRES HER? Tennis legend Roger Federer and other achievers in various sports

ACCOMPLISHMENT

India's only badminton world champion and winner of two consecutive Olympic medals